

TidyTuesday Week 31

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Tuesday 28th July, 2026

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1 Weekly Summary

AI-Generated Content

The summary below was written by Claude (Anthropic) from that week's regression outputs and series descriptions. It has not been reviewed or fact-checked by a human, and should be read as an automated, informal recap – not analysis.

Welcome back to the only newsletter brave enough to yank two economic time series out of a hat, mash them together, and act surprised at the results. This week the machine served up a delightfully lopsided pair of experiments, and I regret to inform you that one of them was actually kind of good, which ruins the whole vibe.

Let's start Monday off with the crowd favorite: the World Pandemic Uncertainty Index for New Zealand versus Total Private Construction Spending on Communication infrastructure in the United States. Yes, you read that correctly – we asked whether Kiwis feeling nervous about pandemics has anything to do with how many dollars Americans throw at communication buildings. The raw regression came back with an R-squared of 0.008, which for the non-nerds means the relationship explains a heroic eight-tenths of one percent of anything, with a p-value of 0.32 that politely declined to be significant. And then, in a rare display of consistency, the detrended version also found nothing (p-value 0.45, R-squared basically a rounding error). So both versions agree: there is no there there. A relationship so weak it stayed weak even after we removed the trend. Truly the null hypothesis's finest hour. Frankly refreshing that the universe occasionally lets a nonsense pairing be nonsense in peace.

Tuesday, however, the algorithm got ambitious and paired two Consumer Price Indexes: core inflation (less food and energy) in the Northeast against Transportation Services inflation nationwide. And oh no, it's real. The raw regression posted an R-squared of 0.97, the kind of number that makes you check whether you accidentally regressed a series against itself. But here's the plot twist that this project usually lives to mock: even after ripping out each series' own time trend, the detrended relationship held up beautifully – R-squared of 0.84, p-value in the neighborhood of ten-to-the-negative-twenty-three, which is science-speak for "we are very sure." So this is the rare, genuinely interesting case: two prices that move together not just because everything drifts upward over the decades, but because, well, they're both prices in the same economy responding to the same broad inflationary forces. Shocking. Inflation correlated with inflation. Alert the journals.

As always, let me remind you before anyone frames this newsletter and hangs it in a hedge fund lobby: these pairs are drawn at random, no theory, no hypothesis, no dignity. Spurious correlation is the house specialty here, not the exception, and even the one relationship that "held up" this week is two flavors of the same underlying thing rather than some daring discovery. So please do not go trading New Zealand pandemic anxiety futures based on American telecom construction. Enjoy the pretty scatterplots, distrust the pretty numbers, and I'll see you next week

when the machine inevitably correlates cheese consumption with bond yields.

2 Date: 2026-07-27

Series ID: WUPINZL

This series is titled World Pandemic Uncertainty Index for New Zealand and has a frequency of Quarterly. The units are Index and the seasonal adjustment is Not Seasonally Adjusted. The observation start date is 1996-01-01 and the observation end date is 2026-01-01. The popularity of this series is 1.

Series ID: PRCMUCON

This series is titled Total Private Construction Spending: Communication in the United States and has a frequency of Monthly. The units are Millions of Dollars and the seasonal adjustment is Not Seasonally Adjusted. The observation start date is 1993-01-01 and the observation end date is 2026-05-01. The popularity of this series is 1.

2.1 Raw Regression

Regresses the two series against each other directly. A significant result here can come just as easily from both series sharing a long-run trend as from any real relationship.

Dep. Variable:	value_fred_PRCMUCON	R-squared:	0.008			
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	-0.000			
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	0.9862			
Date:	Mon, 27 Jul 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	0.323			
Time:	14:06:59	Log-Likelihood:	-897.76			
No. Observations:	121	AIC:	1800.			
Df Residuals:	119	BIC:	1805.			
Df Model:	1					
Covariance Type:	nonrobust					
	coef	std err	t	P> t 	[0.025	0.975]
const	1632.8538	37.497	43.547	0.000	1558.607	1707.101
value_fred_WUPINZL	10.4150	10.487	0.993	0.323	-10.351	31.181
Omnibus:	3.754	Durbin-Watson:	0.365			
Prob(Omnibus):	0.153	Jarque-Bera (JB):	2.215			
Skew:	0.059	Prob(JB):	0.330			
Kurtosis:	2.348	Cond. No.	3.63			

Notes:

[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.

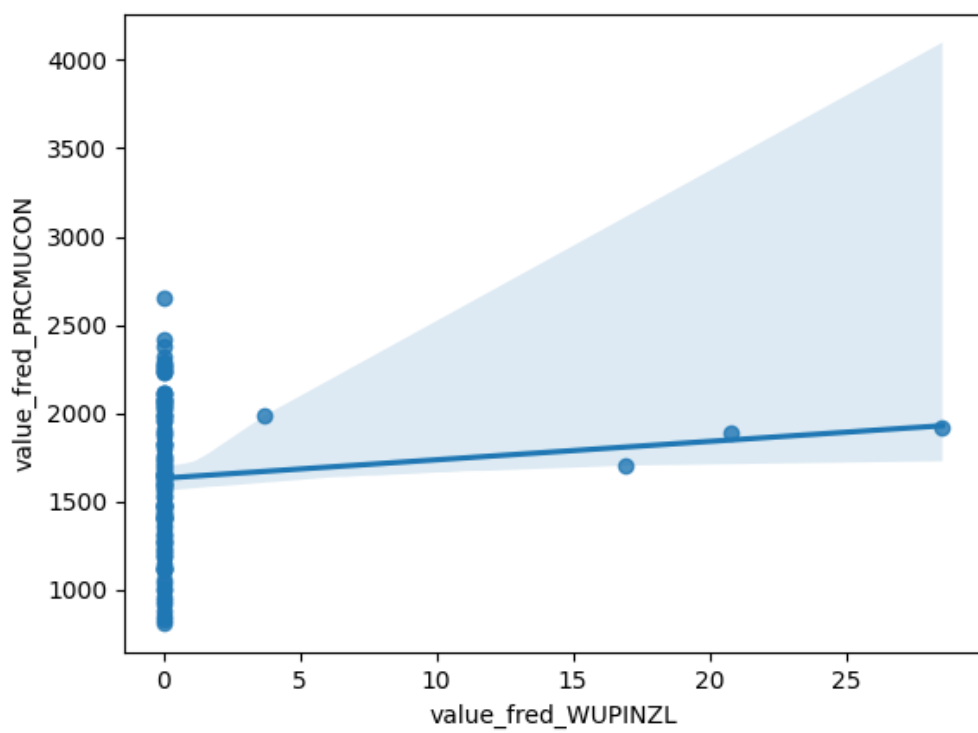


Figure 1: Raw Regression Plot for 2026-07-27

2.2 Detrended Regression

Regresses the residuals of each series after removing its own linear time trend, so a shared trend can no longer drive the result on its own. A relationship that stays significant here is better evidence of a genuine link between the two series.

Dep. Variable:	value_fred_PRCMUCON_detrended	R-squared:	0.005
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	-0.004
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	0.5697
Date:	Mon, 27 Jul 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	0.452
Time:	14:06:59	Log-Likelihood:	-858.73
No. Observations:	121	AIC:	1721.
Df Residuals:	119	BIC:	1727.
Df Model:	1		
Covariance Type:	nonrobust		

	coef	std err	t	P> t	[0.025	0.975]
const	1.119e-11	26.801	4.17e-13	1.000	-53.069	53.069
value_fred_WUPINZL_detrended	-5.8542	7.756	-0.755	0.452	-21.212	9.503

Omnibus:	14.526	Durbin-Watson:	0.687
Prob(Omnibus):	0.001	Jarque-Bera (JB):	17.629
Skew:	0.701	Prob(JB):	0.000149
Kurtosis:	4.238	Cond. No.	3.46

Notes:

[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.

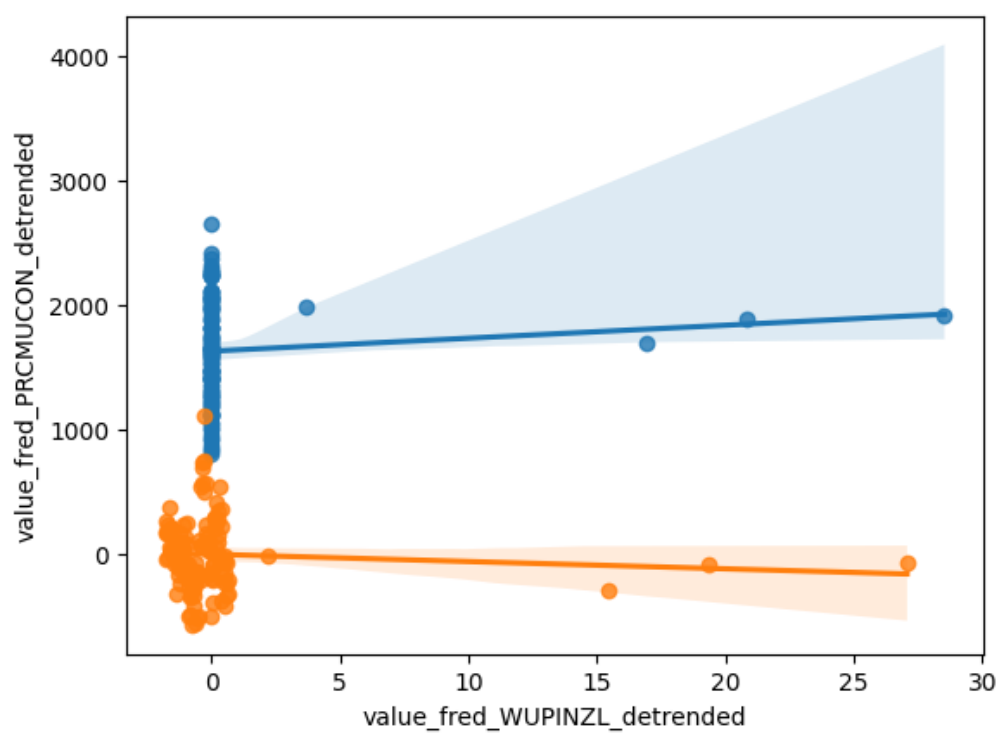


Figure 2: Detrended Regression Plot for 2026-07-27

3 Date: 2026-07-28

Series ID: CUUSX100SA0L1E

This series is titled Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers: All Items Less Food and Energy in Northeast - Size Class B/C and has a frequency of Semiannual. The units are Index Dec 1997=100 and the seasonal adjustment is Not Seasonally Adjusted. The observation start date is 1998-01-01 and the observation end date is 2026-01-01. The popularity of this series is 1.

Series ID: CWSR0000SAS4

This series is titled Consumer Price Index for All Urban Wage Earners and Clerical Workers: Transportation Services in U.S. City Average and has a frequency of Monthly. The units are Index 1982-1984=100 and the seasonal adjustment is Seasonally Adjusted. The observation start date is 1956-01-01 and the observation end date is 2026-06-01. The popularity of this series is 1.

3.1 Raw Regression

Regresses the two series against each other directly. A significant result here can come just as easily from both series sharing a long-run trend as from any real relationship.

Dep. Variable:	value_fred_CWSR0000SAS4	R-squared:	0.974
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	0.973
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	2037.
Date:	Tue, 28 Jul 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	3.80e-45
Time:	13:25:41	Log-Likelihood:	-227.11
No. Observations:	57	AIC:	458.2
Df Residuals:	55	BIC:	462.3
Df Model:	1		
Covariance Type:	nonrobust		

	coef	std err	t	P> t	[0.025	0.975]
const	-174.8164	10.353	-16.886	0.000	-195.564	-154.069
value_fred_CUUSX100SA0L1E	3.3910	0.075	45.134	0.000	3.240	3.542

Omnibus:	1.760	Durbin-Watson:	0.172
Prob(Omnibus):	0.415	Jarque-Bera (JB):	0.997
Skew:	0.247	Prob(JB):	0.607
Kurtosis:	3.420	Cond. No.	813.

Notes:

[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.

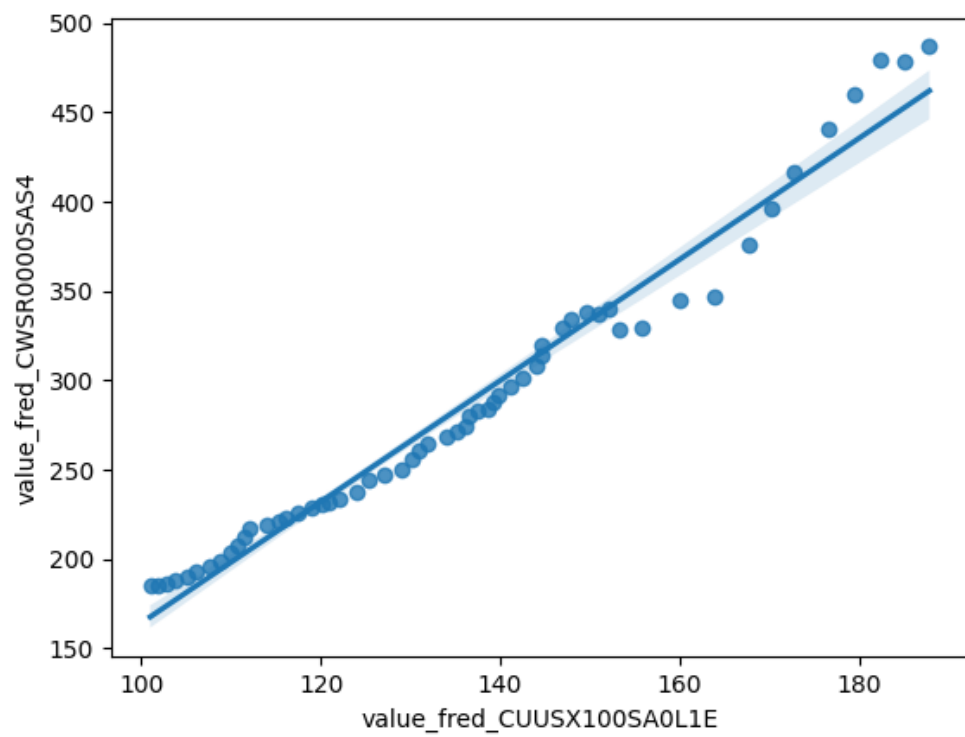


Figure 3: Raw Regression Plot for 2026-07-28

3.2 Detrended Regression

Regresses the residuals of each series after removing its own linear time trend, so a shared trend can no longer drive the result on its own. A relationship that stays significant here is better evidence of a genuine link between the two series.

Dep. Variable:	value_fred_CWSR0000SAS4_detrended	R-squared:	0.841
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	0.838
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	290.1
Date:	Tue, 28 Jul 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	1.35e-23
Time:	13:25:41	Log-Likelihood:	-212.21
No. Observations:	57	AIC:	428.4
Df Residuals:	55	BIC:	432.5
Df Model:	1		
Covariance Type:	nonrobust		

	coef	std err	t	P> t	[0.025	0.975]
const	-1.098e-11	1.350	-8.13e-12	1.000	-2.706	2.706
value_fred_CUUSX100SA0L1E_detrended	5.2535	0.308	17.033	0.000	4.635	5.872

Omnibus:	3.612	Durbin-Watson:	0.292
Prob(Omnibus):	0.164	Jarque-Bera (JB):	2.762
Skew:	-0.345	Prob(JB):	0.251
Kurtosis:	3.828	Cond. No.	4.38

Notes:

[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.

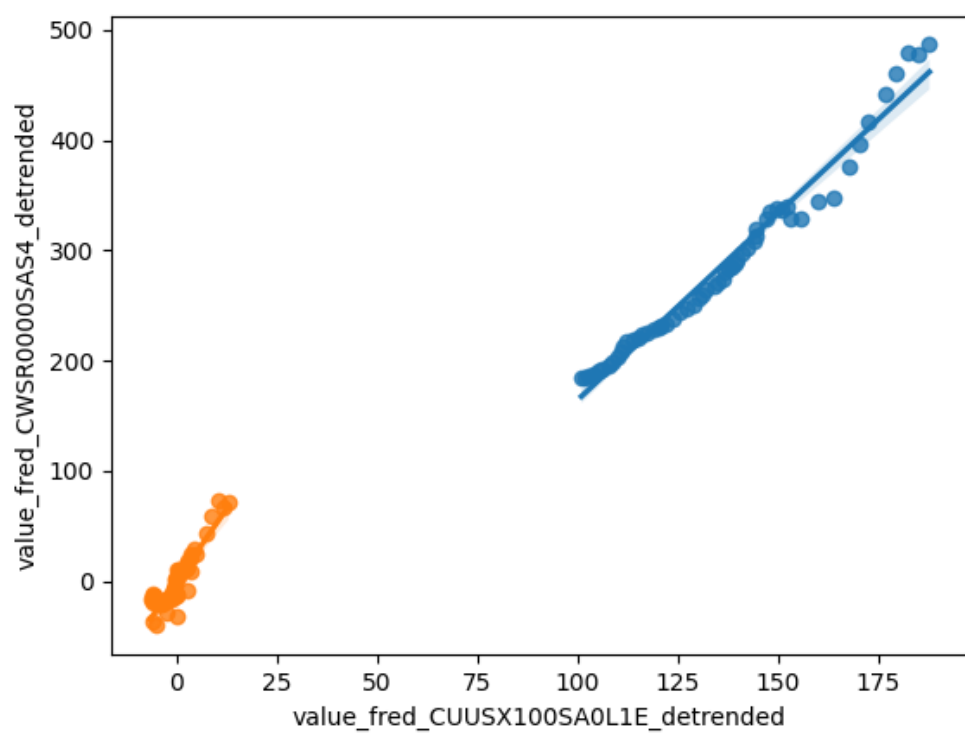


Figure 4: Detrended Regression Plot for 2026-07-28